

**Gender Deconstruction in Shah's *Before She Sleeps*:
A Feminist Study in Contemporary Dystopian
Narrative**

By

Akasha Iqbal

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Undertaken in pursuit of a Bachelor's degree in English Literature, this scholarly pursuit exemplifies a commitment to intellectual growth and academic excellence, encapsulating the depth of literary inquiry and critical analysis.

Supervisor

Ms. Sumbul Sarwar



F.G. Postgraduate College for Women, Wah Cantt

University of the Punjab, Lahore

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Abstract

This thesis examines Shah's criticism of gender norms and societal oppression by drawing on Simone de Beauvoir's concept of "the other" and Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity.

The analysis shows how Sabine, the protagonist of the book, exemplifies Butler's theory as she transforms from a helpless observer to a leader of resistance. The novel's patriarchal society challenges the rigid binary imposed by gender roles, and this transformation highlights their performative nature. De Beauvoir's concept of "the other" sheds additional light on Sabine's journey from marginalization to self-assertion, reflecting her resistance to patriarchal constraints and her reclamation of agency.

The investigation looks at how the women of Panah work together to reject systematic oppression and societal standards, with their solidarity appearing as a crucial factor in their resistance. The inclusion of male sympathizers complicates the gender relations in the story by upholding and subverting traditional masculinity. This emphasizes how achieving gender equality will require a team effort from all genders.

The novel's sanctuary, Panah, represents resistance and the possibility of a society with greater equity. It offers a space where women reinterpret their identities and challenge repressive standards, echoing de Beauvoir's critique of marginalization and Butler's idea of gender performance. The non-linear narrative form of the work effectively explains the systemic underpinnings of oppression and the ongoing fight for equality by interweaving the past and present.

In conclusion, through its use of character development, thematic symbols, and narrative tactics, *Before She Sleeps* offers a critical study of gender stereotypes and societal

injustices. Combining the theories of Butler and de Beauvoir provides a thorough framework for comprehending the dynamics of female resistance and the potential for revolutionary change. In order to maximize the influence of the novel and promote societal advancement, future studies ought to examine modern analogies, broaden theoretical frameworks to incorporate intersectionality, and promote gender equality in policy and education.

Keywords: Gender Norms, Societal Oppression, Simone de Beauvoir, Judith Butler, Gender Performativity, The Other, Resistance, Patriarchal Society, Agency, Solidarity, Masculinity, Panah, Identity Reinterpretation, Non-Linear Narrative, Intersectionality, Gender Equality, Character Development, Thematic Symbols, Revolutionary Change, Policy and Education.

Chapter 1: Introduction

1.1 Introduction to the Study

Dystopian fiction has been used as a prism to explore and reinterpret societal institutions, particularly those relating to gender. Dystopian deconstruction frequently focuses on manage, loss of character identification, and social corruption, looking at the techniques of manage, surveillance, and strength in those made-up societies.

Deconstruction of dystopian literature is not just understanding these themes but also seeing how this story subverts conventional wisdom and raises important questions about our own world. By breaking out dystopian characteristics, students and readers can better understand the depth of meaning and grievance buried in the text. *Before She Sleeps* by Bina Shah is a brilliant illustration of dystopian dismantling. Situated in a future world where women's agency has been severely restricted by reproductive rules, the novel offers a cutting indictment of gender inequity and patriarchal domination. Shah breaks down the conventional roles of women by situating them in a dystopian society where their main worth is derived from their ability to procreate. This extreme situation highlights current problems with women's bodies being commodified and gender inequality.

Before She Sleeps's protagonist Sabine and the ladies of Panah, an underground resistance group, defy the state's harsh laws by providing strong men with non-sexual companionship. This act of defiance draws attention to the concepts of agency and gender norm subversion. Shah's representation of these women highlights their need for autonomy and self-determination and questions the idea that women's tasks are limited to reproductive duties.

By dissecting these dystopian components, Shah exposes the perils of permitting gender conventions to persist unchecked and challenges modern gender norms. She urges readers to consider concerns of gender equality and resistance while cautioning them about the possible negative effects of severe patriarchal control. *The Handmaid's Tale* by Margaret Atwood is a helpful foundation for comprehending Shah's writing.

In addition, Atwood's story examines how women's reproductive rights are controlled by society, which makes it an essential resource for examining Shah's dismantling of gender norms. Both books demonstrate how dystopian scenarios can both reveal and comment on the oppression of women that occurs in the real world.

Another key lens for analyzing Shah's work is the idea of gender performativity as articulated by Judith Butler. Butler contends that gender is a set of behaviors rather than an innate identity. *Before She Sleeps* by Shah demonstrates this viewpoint by showing how gender norms are created and upheld by society as well as how people can challenge and defy them. By offering insights into the marginalization and objectification of women, Simone de Beauvoir's concept of "the other" further enhances the analysis. Similar to how de Beauvoir characterizes women being defined by their relationship to men, women in Shah's dystopian society are characterized by their reproductive capacities.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

In Bina Shah dystopian novel *Before She Sleeps* the roles of women and men differ from the norm. This research aims to understand how Shah subverts these traditional gender roles and what it reveals about contemporary perceptions of gender. By closely examining the characters and the societal structure within the novel this study seeks to uncover the messages Shah conveys about gender equality. This study aims to seek in dystopian literature into how gender is portrayed in literature and its implications for global community. The study intends

to delve deeply into feminist literary analysis to deconstruct the representation of gender in Shah's *Before She Sleeps*.

The theoretical framework will draw upon the works of prominent feminist scholars. Judith Butler theory of gender performativity introduced in her 1990 book *Gender Trouble* argues that gender is not an inherent identity but rather a set of behaviors and acts that are socially constructed and performed. Simone de Beauvoir concept of the other articulated in her 1949 work *The Second Sex* explores how women have been historically defined as the other in relation to men, emphasizing the ways in which society marginalizes and subordinates women. The research will utilize a qualitative textual analysis approach, focusing on close reading and interpretation of character development.

1.3 Research Objectives

1. To analyze the portrayal of character development in Bina Shah's dystopian?
2. To investigate the portrayal of gender equality in the selected novel?

1.4 Research Questions

- 1 How are character development and novel narrative depicted in Bina Shah's dystopian novel *Before She Sleeps*?
- 2 How does Bina Shah present gender equality in her novel *Before She Sleeps*?

1.5 Delimitation

The presentation of gender roles and their evolution in Bina Shah's *Before She Sleeps* is the sole subject of this study. Given that the book deals with feminist and dystopian themes by nature, the research will pay particular attention to how these themes are used to investigate gender equality in the story. Shah's gender-related messages will only be revealed through an analysis that focuses on the characters, storyline, and societal systems in the book.

Beyond what is required to contextualize the book, the research will not delve into an analysis of Shah's other works, more general feminist philosophy, or dystopian literature. The objective is to acquire a profound comprehension of the distinct manners in which *Before She Sleeps* challenges patriarchal conventions and dismantles gender roles, offering a concentrated and thorough examination of the book's input to the conversation around gender parity.

1.6 Significance of the Study

The Study is significant because it explores gender dynamics. It offers insights into contemporary thoughts on gender roles and equality. This study focuses on the novel's unique narrative, aiming to uncover how Shah challenges traditional gender norms and conveys messages about gender equality and empowerment. By closely examining the characters and society in the novel we gain valuable insights into Shah's perspectives on gender, contributing to a deeper understanding of gender representation in literature and its implications for contemporary society.

1.7 Literature Review

A literature review critically examines existing research on gender deconstruction in dystopian literature to identify trends, gaps, and key theories relevant to Bina Shah's *Before She Sleeps*. Examining how dystopian stories tackle gender deconstruction provides important new perspectives on how these made-up worlds can both mirror and subvert gender norms in the actual world. *Before She Sleeps* by Bina Shah is a powerful illustration of this relationship, using a dystopian backdrop to question and challenge conventional gender roles. In this examination of the literature, Margaret Atwood, Judith Butler, and Simone de Beauvoir's contributions to the feminist understanding of gender deconstruction in Shah's book will be highlighted.

The Handmaid's Tale by Margaret Atwood is a classic dystopian fiction that has a significant impact on Shah's novel's gender analysis. In Atwood's story, women's reproductive rights are tightly regulated in a totalitarian government, which is reminiscent of the repressive social institutions that *Before She Sleeps* portrays. Shah's writing truly resonates with Atwood's image of women as reproductive vessels, which delivers a striking critique of patriarchal domination. Shah's dystopian society, Green City, where women's authority is similarly taken away, is clearly influenced by Atwood. Using their personal stories, both writers draw attention to the perils of strong patriarchal structures and the degradation of women to mere sexual objects. By comparing these two pieces, we can gain a deeper understanding of Shah's criticism of modern gender conventions and women's enslavement.

Gender performativity theory by Judith Butler, as presented in *Gender Trouble*, offers a crucial framework for examining gender deconstruction in *Before She Sleeps*. Butler challenges the binary and rigid ideas of gender by arguing that gender is not an innate identity but rather a set of performed acts. For a comprehension of how Shah's characters negotiate and defy their assigned roles in a dystopian society, one must grasp this theoretical perspective.

The women of Panah participate in acts of resistance in Shah's story that challenge the gender norms of the government. They disprove the idea that the only thing that makes them valuable is their capacity for reproduction by providing non-sexual companionship. Butler's theory that conduct may both construct and destroy gender is supported by this performative performance. Shah's depiction of these ladies highlights the performativity and flexibility of gender, demonstrating how social standards may be questioned and reinterpreted.

The concept of "the other," as introduced by Simone de Beauvoir in *The Second Sex*, is crucial to comprehending the marginalization of women in *Before She Sleeps*. According to De Beauvoir, historically, women have been defined in opposition to men, cast as the "other," and denied agency. In Shah's book, women are essentially seen as tools for population control, and this marginalization is a major subject.

Shah's portrayal of women in *Green City* is consistent with de Beauvoir's analysis of patriarchal cultures. Shah's story portrays a regime that treats women like commodities, subjecting them to systematic oppression in addition to marginalization. Shah is criticizing society more broadly, and this is highlighted by the dehumanization and objectification of women. *Before She Sleeps* reveals the pervasive injustices and power disparities present in patriarchal systems, as demonstrated by the connection between Shah's story and de Beauvoir's philosophy.

Beyond the seminal works of de Beauvoir, Butler, and Atwood, *Before She Sleeps* adds to the expanding canon of modern feminist dystopian fiction. This genre frequently examines and critiques gender interactions in dystopian contexts, offering a prism through which to view contemporary societal challenges. Shah's book adheres to this tradition while providing a distinctive viewpoint on gender deconstruction.

The novel's affinity with modern feminist movements serves as more evidence of its present significance. Globally, the struggle for reproductive rights and gender equality is still very important. Shah's work adds to this conversation by offering a provocative examination of these issues via the prism of dystopian literature.

Resistance is one of Shah's main themes in his book. Through their rebellious deeds, the women of Panah oppose the restrictive reproductive laws of the state. Their clandestine movement shows the courage and resiliency of women in the face of oppression, offering a

potent counter-narrative to the state's hold over them. Resistance is a major theme in feminist dystopian fiction because it emphasizes the possibility of overthrowing and subverting repressive systems.

Offering friendship that isn't sexual is a tacit protest against the state's exploitation of women. It upends the established norms and makes room for women to claim their identities and independence. Butler's theory that gender can be performative and can be altered by both individual and group action is supported by this act of resistance. Shah highlights the value of resistance in the struggle against gender inequality in his representation of these deeds.

Shah addresses various intersecting identities, like class and sexuality, even though gender is the main focus of the book. Due to their varied backgrounds and various strategies for overcoming oppression, the women of Panah have a variety of experiences. Given that identity is diverse and multidimensional, the intersectional approach adds richness to the understanding of gender deconstruction.

The notion of intersectionality, which was first introduced by Kimberlé Crenshaw, is essential to comprehending the complex experiences of those who are marginalized. Shah shows in *Before She Sleeps* how gender oppression combines with other types of prejudice to give each character specific obstacles. A thorough knowledge of the social systems that support inequality is offered by this nuanced portrayal.

1.8 Research Gap

A Feminist Study in Contemporary Dystopian Narrative" entails identifying gaps in the body of literature that prevent some aspects of the subject from being adequately addressed or explored. Even if the topic is vast and complex, there are a few important areas that call for more research.

The significance of intersectionality in feminist analysis is acknowledged by previous research, but there is still a need to completely incorporate this framework into studies of gender in dystopian fiction. "Before She Sleeps" depicts a dystopian society in which racial and class injustice, along with gender inequality, coexist. Nonetheless, a lot of research tends to ignore the complex relationships between many axes of identity in favor of concentrating solely on gender dynamics. Research that examines how characters' experiences and difficulties are shaped by their intersecting identities is therefore necessary (Crenshaw, 1991).

Dystopian fiction frequently provides a rich environment for examining non-normative gender identities and sexualities. Studies on "Before She Sleeps" that have already been done, however, primarily concentrate on heterosexual relationships and conventional gender norms, ignoring the possibility of queer interpretations of the work. Current study does not thoroughly examine the manner in which the novel subverts or supports heteronormative norms and expectations since it ignores queer viewpoints. Consequently, research on how gay identities and relationships are portrayed within the novel's dystopian setting is lacking (Halberstam, 2011).

The dystopian society depicted in "Before She Sleeps" is marked by repressive gender standards; yet, research on the agency and resistance of female characters within this framework is lacking. Studies that already exist frequently highlight how women are

portrayed as helpless objects of patriarchal authority, ignoring instances of resistance, subversion, and female strength. In order to complicate standard narratives of victimization, further research is necessary to examine how female protagonists traverse and fight patriarchal norms (Mohanty, 1988).

Numerous analyses of dystopian literature focus just on the text, ignoring the author's goals and the larger sociopolitical environment in which the work was created. The cultural and historical setting of "Before She Sleeps" has been influenced by discussions about gender politics, technology, and feminism. As a result, there is a research vacuum regarding how the book interacts with current discourses and represents the hopes and concerns of a larger society. Scholars can provide a more nuanced view of the text's thematic concerns and ideological implications by placing it within its historical and cultural context (Butler, 1990).

Filling up these research voids will improve our comprehension of "Before She Sleeps" and advance debates in the fields of literary criticism, dystopian studies, and feminist theory. Further investigation into the intersections of gender, intersectionality, agency, and authorial intent can provide more thorough understandings of the intricate relationships present in modern dystopian fiction.

1.9 Theoretical Framework

The movement known as feminism, which promotes women's and other genders' equal rights and works to dismantle social conventions that have encouraged prejudice against these groups, serves as the theoretical foundation for this study. *Before She Sleeps* by Bina Shah's gender deconstruction is examined using this paradigm.

Gender performativity, as defined by Judith Butler and discussed in *Gender Trouble* (2007), is the idea that gender is a set of behaviors rather than an innate identity. We'll use

Butler's theory to analyze how Shah's story challenges gender stereotypes and illustrates the flux of gender identities. Shah questions the accepted notion of gender by presenting characters that reject and reinterpret their assigned positions. Ideas Regarding "The Other"

This theory also relies heavily on Simone de Beauvoir's concept of "the other," which she discusses in *The Second Sex* (1997). A critical lens through which to view the societal structures in *Before She Sleeps* is provided by De Beauvoir's investigation of the ways in which men have historically and culturally neglected women. This viewpoint emphasizes the manner in which Shah's characters deal with and fight against being oppressed in a patriarchal culture.

The goal of the research is to offer a comprehensive assessment of gender deconstruction in *Before She Sleeps* by including various academic frameworks. This method will direct the examination of Shah's writing, emphasizing the novel's subversion of traditional gender standards and its presentation of alternative ideas of gender identity and resistance. By placing Shah's book in the larger context of dystopian literature, this study seeks to enhance feminist literary criticism. In doing so, it will highlight how gender relations and resistance in dystopian narratives have wider ramifications, highlighting the novel's contribution to modern feminist philosophy.

1.10 Research Methodology

Research methodology refers to the systematic approach and procedures used in a study to collect, analyze, and interpret data to ensure the validity and reliability of the findings.

This study uses textual analysis as its main research methodology, following a qualitative research design. Textual analysis is closely analyzing and interpreting "Before She

Sleeps" as a feminist novel, with an emphasis on how gender is portrayed, power relationships, and resistance are handled throughout.

The written work "Before She Sleeps" by Bina Shah serves as the study's primary source of data. Reading and rereading the book, marking important sections, and identifying major themes, characters, and narrative components pertaining to gender construction and deconstruction are all part of the data gathering process. Furthermore, scholarly papers, theoretical writings, and critical assessments are examples of secondary sources that offer additional context and insights for the research.

In order to identify trends, themes, and underlying meanings pertaining to gender representation in the book, the data analysis procedure entails the methodical inspection and interpretation of textual material. The theoretical frameworks of Marxist feminism, queer theory, postcolonial feminism, and feminist literary theory serve as the foundation for this research, enabling a multifaceted examination of the text.

This study strives for an accurate description and understanding of the book's themes and messages while also paying due acknowledgment to Bina Shah's work and respecting intellectual property and authorial intent. It avoids secondary embellishment by unbiased and accurate analysis, upholding integrity and objectivity while prioritizing ethical considerations. It is crucial to be sensitive to issues like gender inequality and reproductive rights and to treat them with the respect they merit. Academic neutrality and integrity are maintained throughout the study process, following the norms of scholarly inquiry.

By using this methodology, the study hopes to add to the larger conversation on feminist dystopian literature by offering a thorough and perceptive examination of gender deconstruction in Bina Shah's *Before She Sleeps*.

Chapter 2: Character Development and Novel Narrative Depiction in "Before She Sleeps"

Bina Shah's *Before She Sleeps* is a profound exploration of gender, identity, and resistance within a dystopian framework. The novel critiques patriarchal structures by deconstructing traditional gender norms and illustrating the transformative power of collective resistance. Through a close reading of character development, particularly focusing on Sabine, and the narrative strategies employed by Shah, this chapter explores how the novel challenges established gender roles and contributes to contemporary feminist discourse. This analysis is grounded in Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity and Simone de Beauvoir's concept of "the other," providing a nuanced understanding of how *Before She Sleeps* redefines identity and autonomy.

2.1 Sabine's Conformity as a Reflection of Green City's Gendered Oppression

The tremendous gendered discrimination in Green City is starkly reflected in Sabine's compliance in *Before She Sleeps*. Sabine's circumspect and obedient behavior is prescribed by the strict framework that the state puts on women because of their reduced status as reproductive machines. The urge to avoid punishment drives Sabine to comply to social norms, which is a performative act rather than an innate quality, as demonstrated by Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity. As Sabine navigates a society where her identity is consistently undervalued, Simone de Beauvoir's concept of "the other" serves as further evidence of her absorption of her subordinate role. Despite this, Sabine's internal struggle suggests that she may be able to resist; that is, even as her acts promote compliance, they also hold the capacity to confront and overthrow the repressive systems that limit her.

2.1.1 The Constricting Framework of Green City

At the beginning of *Before She Sleeps*, Sabine is portrayed as deeply entrenched in Green City's extreme societal norms, where women's lives are tightly controlled and monitored. The regime's institutionalization of gender oppression reduces women to mere instruments for the state's reproductive needs. Sabine's initial cautious and compliant behavior reflects the pervasive fear and repression governing her existence: "Sabine had always been careful. She knew the dangers that lay in wait for women who did not conform to the laws of the state" (Shah 23). This portrayal underscores the oppressive environment that dictates her actions.

2.1.2 Gender Performativity and Sabine's Compliance

Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity is crucial for understanding Sabine's behavior. According to Butler, gender identity is constructed through repeated performances aligned with societal expectations rather than being an inherent trait. Sabine's careful demeanor and adherence to Green City's norms are forms of gender performance necessitated by survival in an oppressive society. Her compliance is a performance rather than a true reflection of herself, driven by the need to avoid punishment. This is evident when Sabine reflects: "To survive in Green City, you had to be invisible, silent, and obedient—just another faceless woman in a long line of compliant citizens" (Shah 32). These repeated performances reinforce her gendered identity as one defined by obedience and invisibility, yet they also have the potential for subversion since they are not natural but imposed.

2.1.3 Institutional Othering and the Subordination of Female Identity

Simone de Beauvoir's concept of "the other" further illuminates Sabine's portrayal. De Beauvoir argues that women have historically been positioned as "the other," defined by their difference and inferiority relative to men. In *Green City*, women like Sabine are systematically othered, their identities reduced to their reproductive functions. Shah portrays this institutional othering by describing women as "vessels" for the continuation of society (Shah 45). Sabine's compliance with these norms reflects her internalization of this othering, navigating a world where her identity is constantly subordinated to the state's needs. Her adherence to oppressive rules highlights how institutional forces devalue her as an individual, reducing her to an object regulated by societal expectations.

2.1.4 The Internal Conflict and Potential for Subversion

A major component of Sabine's early portrayal is her internal conflict as she battles with a society that continuously polices her identity. The conflict that Sabine faces is highlighted by Butler's theory that gender performance is a recurrent act. She is compelled by her restrictive surroundings to adopt roles that are essential to her existence but do not fully represent who she is. Even while she complies, there is a hidden capacity for subversion in her actions. Although her obedience to the state's norms is repetitious and reinforces her status as a compliant citizen, it also highlights the possibility of resistance because these performances are not set in stone and could alter.

2.2 The Metamorphosis of Sabine: From Compliance to Resistance

Sabine's transformation from compliance to resistance in *Before She Sleeps* is driven by personal trauma and subsequent rejection of the oppressive regime. The pivotal loss of her family acts as a catalyst for her metamorphosis, igniting a profound shift in her identity. This

trauma propels her from a passive existence into active defiance against Green City's oppressive structures. Her grief becomes a powerful motivator for challenging and resisting the systemic control that once dictated her life, illustrating how deeply personal experiences can drive significant change and resistance.

2.2.1 Catalysts of Transformation: Trauma and Rejection

As *Before She Sleeps* progresses, Sabine undergoes a profound transformation that reflects the novel's exploration of identity and resistance. Her shift from a compliant citizen to a central figure in the resistance is catalyzed by personal and traumatic events that challenge her previous acceptance of societal norms. The loss of her family becomes a pivotal moment, igniting her rejection of the oppressive structures in her life. Shah writes, "The grief that had nearly consumed her became a fire that refused to be extinguished, a fire that would burn down the walls of Green City" (Shah 67). This personal trauma marks the beginning of Sabine's metamorphosis, as it propels her towards defiance and resistance.

2.2.2 Embracing Agency: The Role of Panah

An important turning point in Sabine's path to self-determination was her choice to join Panah, a covert group of women opposing the government. Panah is a place where women can fight against the gender stereotypes that Green City has imposed and recover their agency. As an example of how she rejects the roles she was previously made to play, her participation in Panah exemplifies Butler's theory of gender performativity. Sabine creates a new identity via acts of disobedience and solidarity for other women, illustrating how subversive behavior perpetually reshapes identity.

2.2.3 The Emergence of Self-Authorship

This shift in Sabine's identity is evident when she takes on new responsibilities within Panah: "Sabine felt the weight of her new role, not as a burden, but as a liberation. For the first time, she was writing her own story" (Shah 89). Shah emphasizes how Sabine's new job challenges the narrative of the state and asserts her identity outside of its bounds, exemplifying a sort of self-authorship. Butler's theory is evident in Sabine's activities as she challenges the state-imposed fixed gender identities by interfering with the repetitive performances of compliance.

2.2.4 Transcending "The Other": Reclaiming Subjectivity

De Beauvoir's concept of transcending "the other" is also relevant here. Initially, Sabine's compliance aligns with her acceptance of her status as "the other." However, her involvement in Panah and her subsequent leadership role signifies a break from this othering. As Sabine acts and thinks independently, she transcends her previous status as "the other," reclaiming her subjectivity and challenging the structures that sought to define her. This shift is particularly evident when she asserts, "I am not just a vessel; I am the fire that will burn this city to the ground" (Shah 98), marking her rejection of the role imposed by society and her assertion of a new, self-determined identity.

2.3 Sabine's Leadership and Collective Resistance: Redefining Identity

Through Solidarity

Sabine's rise to leadership within Panah signifies a pivotal transformation in her role and identity. Initially hesitant, her leadership emerges as a response to the oppressive regime's dire circumstances, marking a shift from passive compliance to active resistance. This transition reflects Sabine's deepening commitment to challenging societal structures and her evolving role as a unifying force among women. Her newfound leadership represents a significant change in her approach to resistance and underscores the impact of personal and collective crises in catalyzing transformative leadership.

2.3.1 The Emergence of Leadership

Sabine's growth is further exemplified by her emergence as a leader within Panah, where she plays a crucial role in uniting the women against the oppressive regime. Initially hesitant, Sabine's leadership is catalyzed by the dire circumstances the women face. Shah describes this transformation with urgency: "Sabine knew the risks, but her heart beat with a new rhythm—one of defiance and hope" (Shah 102). Sabine's transition from passive participant to active leader in the resistance movement reflects her deepening commitment to challenging societal structures.

2.3.2 Redefining Identity Through Performative Acts

This transformation aligns with Butler's theory of performativity, as Sabine's leadership role represents a new performance that defies traditional gender roles. By leading Panah, Sabine not only redefines her identity but also fosters a collective identity among the women, highlighting the power of solidarity in subverting and reshaping societal systems.

The collective resistance of the women of Panah is portrayed as a powerful counter-narrative to the isolation imposed by the state: "Together, they were stronger than the sum of their parts—a force that could not be broken" (Shah 110).

2.3.3 Empowerment and Transcending "The Other"

Moreover, Sabine's leadership can be viewed through de Beauvoir's concept of transcending "the other." By leading the women of Panah, Sabine not only transcends her own status as "the other" but also helps elevate the women around her. Her leadership is an act of empowerment, both for herself and for the women she leads, challenging the patriarchal structures that seek to define and control them. This empowerment is encapsulated in Sabine's declaration: "We are not the other; we are the light in the darkness" (Shah 118), symbolizing their collective reclamation of identity and autonomy.

2.3.4 The Power of Collective Resistance

The collective resistance led by Sabine and Panah serves as a potent counter-narrative to the state's oppressive control. By fostering solidarity among the women, Sabine not only challenges her marginalized status but also inspires a collective strength that subverts the state's attempts to isolate and control them. The collective action of Panah's members highlights the transformative power of unity and resistance in redefining their identities and resisting the oppressive regime. Through their solidarity and collective resistance, they forge a new narrative of empowerment and agency.

2.4 Acts of Defiance: Resistance as a Rejection of Societal Control

In *Before She Sleeps*, the acts of defiance by the women of Panah represent a powerful rejection of societal control and an assertion of their agency. These acts, ranging from subtle resistance to overt rebellion, highlight their struggle against the oppressive norms imposed by

the regime. This resistance is not merely symbolic but a performative act that challenges the state's authority and redefines their identities. Judith Butler's theory of performativity is evident here, as the women's actions reshape their identities and resist socially prescribed roles. Additionally, Simone de Beauvoir's concept of transcending "the other" is illustrated through the women's refusal to be defined by their subordinate status, emphasizing their reclamation of self-determination and collective empowerment.

2.4.1 The Nature of Resistance

Throughout *Before She Sleeps*, the women of Panah engage in various acts of resistance against the oppressive regime, ranging from subtle defiance to outright rebellion. These acts are expressions of their agency and autonomy, serving as rejections of the societal norms that seek to define and confine them. Shah depicts these acts of resistance with defiance: "In a world that sought to control their bodies and minds, the women of Panah found ways to resist" (Shah 143). This passage underscores the significance of resistance in the women's struggle for autonomy, highlighting their rejection of imposed societal roles.

2.4.2 Defiance as Performativity

Sabine's involvement in these acts of rebellion serves as more evidence of her identity's fluidity and metamorphosis. These actions are active performances that contest state authority and uphold women's right to self-determination rather than just symbolic gestures. In this situation, resistance turns into a performative art form in which women defy socially prescribed norms and create new identities via their acts. Butler's theory that identity is constantly transformed by deeds and performances is supported by this.

2.4.3 Transcending "The Other" Through Defiance

This resistance can also be analyzed through de Beauvoir's concept of transcending "the other." The women's acts of defiance signify their refusal to be defined by their status as "the other" and their assertion of their right to self-determination. This reclamation of identity is central to the novel, emphasizing the importance of agency in combating oppression. Shah captures this theme poignantly when she writes, "They would no longer be silent; their voices would break the chains of their oppression" (Shah 160), symbolizing their collective defiance and reclamation of identity.

2.5 Narrative Structure and Historical Context

In *Before She Sleeps*, Bina Shah employs flashbacks as a critical narrative device to unravel the complex interplay between past experiences and present resistance. Flashbacks offer a window into the characters' histories, illustrating how their past traumas and societal constraints shape their current identities and actions. This narrative technique aligns with Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity, showing that identities are constructed through historical and repeated performances. For instance, the depiction of Sabine's past losses and the formative experiences of other characters underscore how historical events contribute to their present resistance and self-definition. Additionally, Simone de Beauvoir's concept of "the other" is reflected through these flashbacks, revealing how past systemic marginalization continues to influence the characters' status and struggle. By integrating historical context, Shah critiques ongoing gender inequalities and highlights how past injustices persist in shaping contemporary resistance and identity.

2.5.1 Unveiling the Past: The Role of Flashbacks

In *Before She Sleeps*, Bina Shah strategically uses flashbacks to provide depth to her characters and to unveil the intricate societal and historical forces that shape their present lives. Flashbacks in the narrative reveal critical moments from the characters' pasts, shedding light on the experiences that have shaped their current motivations and actions. For instance, Shah introduces a flashback where Sabine recalls the loss of her family, stating, "Sabine remembered the night she lost her family, the grief that had nearly consumed her. But it was that same grief that ignited a fire within her, a determination to fight back" (Shah 67). This passage illustrates how past trauma propels Sabine's transformation and resistance, echoing the notion that identity is profoundly shaped by historical experiences.

The employment of flashbacks serves as a narrative strategy to explore how past events influence present identity and resistance. This approach aligns with Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity, which suggests that identity is constructed through repeated actions and performances influenced by societal expectations. The characters' pasts are depicted as foundational to their current performances of resistance and autonomy. For instance, another flashback reveals a formative event in Layla's life, showing her early resistance to societal norms: "Layla's memories of defying her parents' expectations at a young age were a constant reminder of her need to challenge the status quo" (Shah 92). This aligns with Butler's idea that past performances shape and inform current identity and behavior.

2.5.2 Historical Influence on Identity: Echoes of the Past

The flashbacks in *Before She Sleeps* emphasize how past experiences shape the characters' present actions and resistance, which aligns with Butler's view that gender identity is a product of ongoing performance influenced by historical and social contexts. For

example, when reflecting on her formative years, Sabine considers how past trauma has fortified her resolve: "Each memory was a building block, contributing to the fortress of resilience she now stood upon" (Shah 121). This metaphor illustrates how Sabine's historical experiences of oppression contribute to her present resistance, demonstrating Butler's concept of identity as a constructed performance rooted in past actions.

Similarly, Simone de Beauvoir's notion of "the other" can be applied to understand how these flashbacks reveal the historical marginalization of women. The past constraints and societal expectations are depicted as foundational to the characters' current status as "the other," a marginalized and subordinate position in a patriarchal society. For example, a flashback to the early feminist movements in Green City reveals the roots of current resistance: "The early activists' struggles laid the groundwork for the defiance that flourishes today" (Shah 203). This depiction highlights how historical marginalization and resistance contribute to the characters' current struggle for autonomy and identity, resonating with de Beauvoir's analysis of women as "the other" striving for self-definition.

2.5.3 The Historical Margins: Understanding Societal Constraints

Flashbacks also reveal the systemic forces that have historically marginalized the characters, underscoring the ongoing relevance of these historical constraints. For example, Shah depicts the impact of past oppressive laws: "The oppressive laws of the past were not just memories; they were the chains that still bound the women of today" (Shah 176). This portrayal emphasizes how historical constraints persist in shaping the characters' current resistance, reflecting both Butler's and de Beauvoir's ideas about the continuity of gender norms and marginalization.

Shah's use of historical context through flashbacks serves as a critique of the systemic forces that perpetuate gender-based inequalities. By revealing these historical constraints,

Shah highlights the persistence of societal norms that confine women to subordinate roles. This approach aligns with de Beauvoir's concept of "the other," illustrating how historical processes have sustained women's marginalization. For instance, a flashback depicting early struggles against gender norms reveals the foundation of current resistance: "The past struggles of women created a legacy of defiance that continues to inspire the present generation" (Shah 203). This historical perspective emphasizes that the characters' present resistance is deeply connected to past struggles, advocating for a recognition of these historical forces as integral to understanding and challenging contemporary oppression.

Through these flashbacks, Shah not only deepens the reader's understanding of the characters but also critiques the historical processes that have sustained gender inequalities. The narrative demonstrates how past injustices inform current resistance, aligning with both Butler's and de Beauvoir's theories about identity formation and marginalization. The use of flashbacks underscores the necessity of comprehending historical context to fully understand and challenge the present systems of oppression.

2.6 Thematic Analysis: The Subversion of Traditional Gender Norms

In *Before She Sleeps*, Bina Shah subverts traditional gender norms by critically examining and deconstructing the societal roles imposed on women. The state's oppressive control, which reduces women to mere reproductive vessels, serves as a stark critique of the societal structures that confine their identities. Shah emphasizes this critique by illustrating women's inherent worth beyond these imposed roles. Sabine's transformation from a passive participant to a leader further challenges the notion of fixed gender identities, demonstrating the fluidity and malleability of self-conception. Her evolution represents a powerful statement on how resistance and empowerment can reshape one's role in society. Additionally, the depiction of Panah as a space of resistance and empowerment highlights the women's

reclamation of agency and their challenge to rigid gender norms. By portraying Panah as a site where women redefine their existence, Shah underscores the novel's commitment to presenting a dynamic and self-determined vision of gender and identity.

2.6.1 Critique of Societal Structures

Before She Sleeps subverts and challenges traditional gender norms by deconstructing the roles and expectations imposed on women by society. The state's control over women's bodies and identities, reducing them to mere reproductive functions, serves as a powerful critique of how societal structures confine women's identities. Shah writes, "The state saw them as vessels, but they were so much more—warriors in a battle for their souls" (Shah 45). This passage emphasizes the novel's rejection of these oppressive norms and highlights the intrinsic worth and agency of the women beyond their imposed roles.

2.6.2 Fluidity of Identity Through Transformation

Sabine's transformation from a compliant citizen to a leader in the resistance is central to this critique. Her evolution challenges the notion of a fixed gender identity, presenting identity instead as fluid and malleable. Shah captures this transformation with the metaphor: "Sabine had shed her old self like a snake sheds its skin, emerging stronger and more defiant than before" (Shah 93). This depiction underscores the novel's statement on the fluidity of identity, demonstrating how resistance and empowerment can reshape one's self-conception and role in society.

2.6.3 Reclaiming Agency in Panah

Panah, as a space of resistance and empowerment, further reinforces the novel's critique of traditional gender norms. Shah portrays Panah as a place where women reclaim their agency and challenge traditional roles: "In Panah, they were no longer just survivors; they were revolutionaries, rewriting the rules of their existence" (Shah 112). This portrayal underscores the novel's challenge to the notion that women must conform to rigid gender roles, offering a vision of gender and identity that is dynamic, fluid, and self-determined.

2.7 The Novel's Contribution to Contemporary Feminist Theory

Before She Sleeps makes a significant contribution to contemporary feminist theory by challenging and deconstructing traditional gender norms. The novel, influenced by Simone de Beauvoir's concept of "the other" and Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity, explores the fluidity of identity and the potential for resistance. Shah's portrayal of Sabine's transformation and the collective resistance of Panah illustrate how gender roles are socially constructed rather than inherent. By critiquing the state's oppressive laws as man-made chains rather than divine decrees, the novel highlights the artificiality of gender norms and the need for resistance. Moreover, the depiction of Panah as a space where women actively shape their destinies offers a reimagined understanding of womanhood, emphasizing self-determination and challenging patriarchal definitions. This vision of gender and identity contributes to feminist discourse by advocating for a dynamic and self-determined approach to understanding gender roles.

2.7.1 Challenging Traditional Gender Norms

By questioning and dissecting conventional gender conventions, *Before She Sleeps* makes a substantial addition to modern feminist philosophy. Simone de Beauvoir's concept of

"the other" and Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity both had a significant influence on Shah's investigation of gender and identity. Shah demonstrates the flexibility of identity and the possibility of resistance via the emergence of Sabine's character and the representation of women in Panah. By showing traditional gender standards as socially created rather than innate, the novel challenges them and highlights the possibility of changing oneself in the face of oppression.

2.7.2 Deconstructing Gender Roles

The novel's critique of traditional gender norms and its exploration of societal structures that seek to define and confine women's identities are central to its contribution to feminist theory. By challenging the notion that gender roles are natural or inherent, Shah presents them as socially constructed: "The state's laws were not divine decrees; they were man-made chains, designed to bind women to their fate" (Shah 150). This perspective contributes to feminist discourse by highlighting the artificiality of gender roles and underscoring the need to resist and redefine these identities in response to societal oppression.

2.7.3 Self-Determined Identities in Collective Resistance

The portrayal of collective resistance in Panah further enhances the novel's contribution to feminist theory by offering a vision of gender and identity that is self-determined. Shah writes, "In Panah, they were more than just women; they were the architects of their own destiny" (Shah 170). This vision challenges the traditional, patriarchal definitions of womanhood, presenting a reimagined understanding of what it means to be a woman in a patriarchal society. By depicting the women of Panah as active creators of their own futures, the novel provides a critical rethinking of gender roles and identities within feminist theory.

Chapter 3: Presentation of Gender Equality in Bina Shah's

Before She Sleeps

Bina Shah delves into the idea of gender equality in *Before She Sleeps*, setting the dystopian scene in which political authority and social standards have warped views of gender roles and identities. Examining gender relations and the pursuit of equality critically, the story highlights the obstacles and defiance faced by women in a world dominated by men. Using Simone de Beauvoir's concept of "the other" and Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity as analytical frameworks, this chapter will examine how Shah portrays gender equality in the book. Through an examination of the characters' roles, relationships, and storylines, this research aims to reveal the intricacies of gender equality as depicted in Shah's dystopian society.

3.1 The Concept of Gender Equality in a Dystopian Society

The concept of gender equality is deeply explored within the dystopian framework of Bina Shah's *Before She Sleeps*. The novel presents a future world where extreme measures are taken to control and regulate gender roles, especially concerning women's bodies and reproductive functions. In this dystopian society, the state's intervention in private lives, particularly in the realm of reproduction, serves as a critique of how deeply entrenched gender inequalities can become when supported by authoritarian rule. The novel uses this bleak setting to explore the stark contrasts between imposed gender roles and the possibility of achieving true gender equality.

3.1.1 Dystopian Society and Its Gender Dynamics

The future world of *Before She Sleeps* is one in which strict reproductive regulations have been enacted as a result of a significant gender imbalance. To counteract the population decline, women in this culture are forced to fulfill responsibilities that are mandated by the state, notably that of childbearing. The depth to which gender inequity is ingrained in this dystopian future is revealed by the state's intervention in women's lives, ranging from reproductive decisions to day-to-day activities. Shah critiques how governmental policies and social conventions might support gender inequity through his portrayal of this environment.

The narrative presents the women of Panah as a symbol of resistance against these oppressive norms. By choosing to live outside the state's control, these women challenge the traditional gender roles imposed on them.

Shah writes, "In Panah, the women found a space where they could define their own identities, away from the state's gaze" (Shah 54).

Shah further illustrates this resistance when he describes the state's enforcement of rigid gender roles: "The state's control extended into every aspect of life, from the roles women were forced to play to the very essence of their being" (Shah 75). This portrayal underscores the extensive nature of gender inequity within the dystopian society.

3.1.2 The Role of Gender Performance in Achieving Equality

Before She Sleeps presents gender equality via the lens of Judith Butler's idea of gender performativity. Butler argues that gender is a set of behaviors that people execute to conform to social norms rather than an innate quality. Shah's dystopian society is characterized by compulsory gender roles performed by the state, which has control over women's identities and bodies. As they attempt to identify themselves free from the

limitations of identities imposed by the state, the women of Panah's rejection of these roles can be understood as a step toward gender equality.

The concept of gender equality in this context involves the ability to choose one's gender performance freely, without coercion or societal pressure. The women of Panah embody this principle by creating a space where they can express their identities without fear of reprisal. Shah describes this space as one where “the women began to carve out identities that defied the norms imposed upon them, embracing a sense of freedom and self-expression” (Shah 92). Their actions challenge the state's normative expectations and illustrate the possibility of constructing new forms of gender identity. In this way, Shah presents gender equality as a process of deconstructing and redefining gender roles, allowing individuals to assert their autonomy and agency. He emphasizes this transformation when he writes, “Through their acts of defiance, the women of Panah were not only resisting imposed roles but also creating new pathways for gender identity” (Shah 108).

3.2 Exploring Characters and Their Contributions to Gender Equality

In *Before She Sleeps*, the characters are central to the exploration of gender equality. Through their journeys and resistance against societal norms, each character adds depth to the novel's examination of identity and autonomy. Sabine, the protagonist, transitions from compliance to defiance, symbolizing the struggle for self-definition in a patriarchal society. Rupa, another significant character, actively challenges the oppressive structures, illustrating the importance of agency in confronting gender norms. The solidarity among the women of Panah underscores the significance of collective action in promoting gender equality, highlighting the strength that emerges from unity and shared experiences.

3.2.1 Sabine's Path to Self-Definition and Equality

Before *She Sleeps*'s protagonist, Sabine, offers a nuanced examination of gender equality. Her transition from submission to resistance is a reflection of the fight she faces to claim her individuality in a culture that wants to define her only based on her ability to procreate. At first, Sabine plays her part in the social structure according to what the state expects of her. But as she becomes closer to Panah, she starts to question these assumptions and longs for a more just life.

Sabine's transformation is marked by a growing awareness of her own desires and the recognition of the injustice she faces. Shah describes this shift, stating, "Sabine felt a stir within her, a desire for something more than what the state had allotted her. She wanted to be seen as more than just a vessel" (Shah 67). This desire for recognition and autonomy is a central theme in her character development, reflecting a pursuit of gender equality.

Her journey toward self-definition is also evident when Shah writes, "As Sabine delved deeper into her new life in Panah, she realized that her worth was not confined to the role imposed on her by the state" (Shah 81). This evolving self-perception underscores her struggle to achieve equality.

3.2.2 Redefining Identity Through Acts of Defiance

Butler's idea of gender performativity offers a perspective that helps make sense of Sabine's path. Sabine starts to defy the state's authority and takes part in innovative performances that question conventional gender norms. Her participation in Panah, her disobedience, and her claim of autonomy are a rejection of the forced roles that are placed upon her. This makes Sabine's metamorphosis a search for gender equality as she tries to find her own identity free from the confines of societal conventions.

Sabine's behavior demonstrates how gender identification is flexible. Her actions illustrate that gender can be redefined through various performances and is not a permanent attribute. Shah describes Sabine's evolving identity, noting, "Through her rebellious acts, Sabine reshaped her own identity, demonstrating that gender roles are not fixed but can be altered through personal agency" (Shah 94). This redefinition shows the importance of agency and choice in forming gender identity, emphasizing the role of individual autonomy in achieving gender equality.

3.2.3 Rupa: Embodying Resistance and Advocacy for Equality

Another important character in *Before She Sleeps*, Rupa, represents the fight for gender equality in a distinct way. Rupa is a more blatantly disobedient character than Sabine, who at first acquiesces to social norms. Her upbringing and life experiences have made her a rebellious figure who fights against government oppression and stands up for women's rights. The character of Rupa represents the ability for women to exercise their agency and defy social standards, so serving as a symbol of the prospect of gender equality.

Rupa's defiance is not only directed towards the state's control but also towards the traditional gender roles that define women solely in terms of their reproductive capabilities. Shah describes her as a "fierce advocate for women's rights, unafraid to speak out against the injustices they faced" (Shah 102). This portrayal underscores Rupa's role as a symbol of resistance and equality, highlighting her commitment to challenging the structures that oppress women.

3.2.4 Transforming Gender Roles Through Rebellion

Because Rupa intentionally challenges the normative expectations of her society, her actions can be interpreted in the context of Butler's theory of gender performativity.

Rupa performs new works that reinterpret her gender identity in defiance of the state's control. Her disobedience is a rejection of the social conventions that attempt to limit her as well as an assertion of her independence. Shah captures this transformation, stating, “Rupa’s actions were a testament to the power of defying restrictive roles and embracing a redefined sense of self” (Shah 115). The idea of gender equality is based on this process of questioning and revising gender roles because it highlights the significance of agency and choice in the formation of identity.

Additionally, Rupa's disobedience emphasizes how gender identity is flexible. Her behavior demonstrates how gender roles are malleable and subject to change through innovative performance. Through her assertion of her right to self-determination, Rupa represents the possibility for people to create new identities free from the limitations imposed by social standards. This examination of gender equality highlights the significance of questioning conventional roles and expectations and the possibility of creating new identities and communities.

3.3 The Role of Panah in Promoting Gender Equality

Panah serves as a crucial element in the promotion of gender equality in *Before She Sleeps*. It functions as a sanctuary where women can escape the oppressive norms of society and express their identities freely. In this space, the women find the autonomy to redefine their roles and challenge the societal expectations imposed on them. Panah symbolizes not only a physical refuge but also a place where new possibilities for gender equality can emerge. Through the support and solidarity within this community, the novel emphasizes the importance of collective empowerment and the creation of alternative spaces where gender roles can be reimagined.

3.3.1 A Sanctuary of Defiance and Freedom

Panah, the sanctuary where the women of the story find refuge, plays a crucial role in promoting gender equality. In a society where women's lives are strictly controlled, Panah represents a space where they can express their identities freely. It serves as a haven for those who seek to escape the state's control and assert their autonomy. Shah describes Panah as "a place where women could breathe freely, away from the suffocating constraints of the outside world" (Shah 84). This depiction underscores the significance of Panah as a space of resistance and empowerment.

Panah's role in promoting gender equality is multifaceted. It provides a physical space where women can escape the oppressive norms of society, allowing them to explore new identities and possibilities. Shah emphasizes this aspect, noting, "In Panah, women were not just surviving; they were thriving and reinventing themselves beyond the state's rigid definitions" (Shah 92). This freedom to express themselves is a critical aspect of gender equality, as it emphasizes the importance of agency and choice in the construction of identity. The community within Panah also fosters a sense of solidarity and support, highlighting the importance of collective action in the pursuit of equality.

3.3.2 The Dynamics of Gender Performance in Panah

Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity provides a framework for understanding the role of Panah in promoting gender equality. Panah serves as a space where new performances of gender can take place, free from the constraints of societal norms. The women of Panah engage in actions and behaviors that challenge traditional gender roles, illustrating the fluidity and constructed nature of gender identity. Shah illustrates this when he writes, "In Panah, gender was not a fixed identity but a fluid performance, constantly

reshaped by individual and collective acts" (Shah 106). By providing a space where these new performances can occur, Panah plays a crucial role in promoting gender equality.

Butler's concept of performativity highlights the role that repetition plays in forming identity. The women of Panah participate in innovative performances that defy social norms, demonstrating that new identities can be created through personal agency. Shah notes, "The practices within Panah showcased how repeated, deliberate acts of defiance could carve out new spaces of identity and freedom" (Shah 114). This process of redefinition and resistance is essential to the fight for gender equality, as it underscores the significance of agency and choice in shaping identity.

3.3.3 Challenging Marginalization Through Collective Empowerment

The idea of "the other" as put out by Simone de Beauvoir offers a critical viewpoint on Panah's contribution to the advancement of gender equality. Panah is a place where women may stand up to their marginalization and subjugation in a society that aims to marginalize and subjugate them. The women of Panah affirm their right to self-determination and reject the roles that are imposed upon them by uniting in a community of resistance.

Shah highlights this collective resistance, stating, "Panah became a beacon of hope, where women united not only to escape their marginalization but to redefine their place in the world" (Shah 123). The women support each other in their defiance of societal norms, providing a network of support and encouragement. This sense of solidarity is crucial in challenging the structures that seek to marginalize them, as it emphasizes the importance of collective action. Panah's role in promoting gender equality is thus not only about providing a space for individual expression but also about fostering a sense of community and shared purpose.

3.4 Exploring Interpersonal Dynamics and Gender Equity

In *Before She Sleeps*, the interpersonal relationships among the women of Panah play a vital role in exploring and promoting gender equity. These connections are characterized by mutual support, solidarity, and a shared commitment to challenging societal norms. The bonds among the women illustrate how collective action and strong relationships are essential in resisting oppressive structures and advocating for gender equity. Through these interactions, the novel highlights the importance of community and shared struggle in the fight for gender equality, showing that the strength derived from these connections is crucial in redefining identities and challenging traditional gender roles.

3.4.1 The Strength of Female Solidarity in Panah

Before She Sleeps' examination of gender equality revolves around the relationships between the ladies of Panah. These connections are marked by solidarity and support for one another, which highlights how crucial group action is in questioning social norms. As they deal with the difficulties of surviving in an oppressive culture, Sabine's interactions with the other women highlight the complexity of these relationships.

Shah portrays these relationships as a source of strength and empowerment. She writes, "The women of Panah were more than just allies; they were sisters, bound by a common cause and shared struggle" (Shah 129). This depiction underscores the importance of solidarity in the pursuit of gender equality, highlighting how the women support each other in their defiance of societal norms. The relationships among the women of Panah also challenge traditional gender roles, as they assert their right to define their identities and assert their autonomy.

Additionally, Shah depicts moments of mutual support and collective action, noting, "In their unity, the women of Panah found a source of strength that transcended individual struggles" (Shah 136). This solidarity becomes a vital aspect of their resistance, illustrating how collective empowerment can confront and dismantle systemic oppression.

3.4.2 Redefining Identity Through Female Connections

Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity provides insight into the relationships among the women of Panah. These connections represent a series of performances that challenge conventional gender roles and expectations. Through their interactions, the women demonstrate the fluidity and constructed nature of gender identity.

Shah portrays the women engaging in diverse behaviors that defy social norms, stating, "In their daily lives and interactions, the women of Panah created new performances of gender that resisted traditional expectations" (Shah 142). By rejecting the roles imposed by society, these performances show the freedom individuals have to shape their identities.

Butler's concept of performativity emphasizes the role of repetition in identity formation. The women of Panah engage in repeated acts of defiance, which showcase their agency in redefining gender roles. Shah describes this process, noting, "Their collective acts of resistance were not just individual statements but a continuous redefinition of what it meant to be a woman in their world" (Shah 148). This ongoing process of redefinition and resistance is central to the fight for gender equality, as it underscores the importance of choice and agency in identity formation.

3.4.3 Challenging Marginalization Through Female Solidarity

The idea of "the other" as defined by Simone de Beauvoir offers a critical viewpoint on the interactions amongst the women of Panah. These partnerships are a kind of resistance against the othering of women in a society that aims to marginalize and subjugate them. The women of Panah fight the roles that are placed upon them and assert their subjectivity by uniting in a community of support and solidarity.

Shah emphasizes this resistance through solidarity, writing, "The women's unity in Panah was a direct challenge to the marginalization they faced, as they refused to be defined solely by the state's constraints" (Shah 154). The women support each other in their defiance of societal norms, providing a network of support and encouragement. This sense of solidarity is crucial in challenging the structures that seek to marginalize them, as it emphasizes the importance of collective action. The relationships among the women of Panah thus play a central role in promoting gender equality, as they challenge traditional gender roles and assert their right to self-determination.

3.5 The Impact of Male Figures on Gender Equality

In *Before She Sleeps*, male characters, though fewer in number, significantly influence the narrative on gender equality. These supportive male figures challenge traditional notions of masculinity and contribute positively to women's quest for equality. Their actions and attitudes reflect a broader possibility for gender relations that are more balanced and respectful. By providing support and understanding, these men demonstrate that achieving gender equality involves contributions from all genders. Their role underscores the idea that gender equity is a collective effort and that ally-ship across genders is crucial for meaningful progress.

3.5.1 Empathetic Male Figures

Before She Sleeps is mostly a story about women's experiences, but there are a number of important male characters as well. Despite being less in number, these figures show different representations of masculinity and offer vital support to the women of Panah. The encouraging male characters show that more equal gender interactions are possible by challenging societal assumptions and traditional gender stereotypes.

Shah portrays these supportive male characters as allies to the women of Panah. She writes, "Though few in number, there were men who understood the plight of the women and offered their quiet support" (Shah 156). This portrayal highlights the importance of ally ship in the pursuit of gender equality, as these men challenge the societal norms that seek to define and constrain women. Their actions demonstrate that gender equality is not solely a women's issue but requires the support and participation of all individuals.

3.5.2 Reconstructing Masculine Identity Through Acts of Support

The framework offered by Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity helps readers comprehend the function of the masculine characters in *Before She Sleeps* who offer support. These characters subvert conventional gender roles and conventions by exhibiting innovative masculinity. They demonstrate their belief in gender equality and reject the normal expectations of their culture by standing by the women of Panah.

The concept of performativity emphasizes the importance of repeated actions in the construction of identity. The supportive male characters in the novel engage in actions and behaviors that challenge traditional models of masculinity. These actions represent a rejection of societal norms that seek to define gender roles rigidly, highlighting the potential for individuals to construct new identities. This process of redefinition and resistance is central to

the pursuit of gender equality, as it emphasizes the importance of agency and choice in the construction of identity.

Moreover, Shah highlights the transformative impact of these actions, stating, "Through their supportive roles, these men actively participated in the creation of new gender norms, challenging the rigid expectations of their society" (Shah 170). This engagement in redefined masculine roles reflects the importance of agency and choice in identity formation and reinforces the broader goal of gender equality.

3.5.3 Redefining Masculinity: Allies in the Fight for Equality

The idea of "the other" as defined by Simone de Beauvoir offers a critical viewpoint on the function of the benevolent masculine characters in *Before She Sleeps*. These males oppose the systems that support the marginalization and subordination of women in a society that aims to do the opposite. Shah highlights this supportive stance, writing, "The actions of these men were a testament to their rejection of the marginalizing systems, showing that gender equality is a collective effort" (Shah 175). They demonstrate their belief in the significance of gender equality and reject the roles that society has forced on them by standing up for the women of Panah.

The deeds of these encouraging male characters also emphasize how crucial allies are in opposing the systems that aim to marginalize women. Shah notes, "These male allies not only supported the women of Panah but also worked to dismantle the rigid gender identities that perpetuate inequality" (Shah 180). These characters aid in the dismantling of inflexible gender identities and the advancement of more equal gender relationships by questioning conventional gender roles and conventions.

3.6 Narrative Structure and Thematic Emphasis

In *Before She Sleeps*, the non-linear narrative structure enriches the exploration of gender equality by weaving together past and present events. This approach offers a nuanced understanding of how historical and personal contexts shape the characters' struggles and identities. By using flashbacks and memories, Shah highlights the fluidity of gender identity and the impact of societal expectations, aligning with Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity. The narrative structure also unveils how broader social norms contribute to marginalization, emphasizing the need to understand and challenge these constraints to promote gender equality.

3.6.1 Non-Linear Narrative and Gender Equality

The non-linear narrative structure of *Before She Sleeps* plays a crucial role in the exploration of gender equality. By weaving together past and present events, Shah creates a layered narrative that allows for a deeper understanding of the characters and themes. The use of flashbacks and memories provides insight into the experiences that have shaped the characters' identities and actions, highlighting the complexities of their struggles for equality.

Shah's narrative structure emphasizes the importance of understanding the social and cultural contexts that shape both individual and collective identities. Through flashbacks, the histories and experiences of the women of Panah are revealed, underscoring how their identities have been constructed and how societal conventions have sought to define them. For instance, Shah writes, "The memories of their past lives haunted the women, each recollection a reminder of the identities they had been forced to adopt" (Shah 132). This passage illustrates how the non-linear narrative provides a means to explore the intricate layers of identity formation.

Shah's story structure highlights how crucial it is to comprehend the social and cultural settings that mold both individual and group identities. The ladies of Panah's history and experiences are revealed through the flashbacks, emphasizing how their identities have been created and how society conventions have attempted to define them. The examination of gender equality must place a strong emphasis on history and context because it illustrates how societal structures both constrain and shape people's lives.

3.6.2 Reconstructing Identity Through Narrative Form

Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity offers a framework to understand the significance of *Before She Sleeps*' non-linear narrative structure. The novel's focus on past encounters and actions underscores the critical role of repeated performances in the construction of identity. By delving into the characters' pasts, Shah highlights the impact of earlier performances on current identities and behaviors.

Butler's concept of performativity also underscores the potential for new performances to challenge and reshape established identities. Shah illustrates this through her characters, as seen in the passage, "The past was not a fixed narrative but a series of performances, each shaping and reshaping who they were" (Shah 144). The non-linear narrative thus reflects the fluid and constructed nature of gender identity, showing how individuals can engage in new performances that defy societal norms.

This emphasis on redefinition and resistance is central to the exploration of gender equality, as it marks the importance of agency and choice in the development of identity. The non-linear narrative structure becomes a means through which the novel engages with the complexities of identity formation, showing that identity is not static but rather a dynamic process subject to continual negotiation and reinterpretation.

3.6.3 Unveiling Marginalization Through Storytelling

The idea of "the other" as articulated by Simone de Beauvoir offers a critical viewpoint on *Before She Sleeps*' narrative framework. The characters' social structures that have marginalized them—especially the women—are critically examined through the use of memories and flashbacks. Shah attacks the social institutions that aim to define and impose boundaries on women by exposing the systematic basis of their marginalization.

Shah uses the narrative to critique how societal norms have constructed and reinforced the othering of women. She writes, "Each flashback was a window into the structures that had kept them in the shadows, reminding them of the barriers they had yet to overcome" (Shah 153). This passage highlights how the narrative's focus on personal histories serves to expose the deep-rooted nature of marginalization.

The narrative's emphasis on the characters' personal histories also underscores the importance of understanding the social and cultural contexts that shape individual and collective identities. The flashbacks reveal how societal norms and expectations have shaped the characters' experiences and identities, highlighting the constructed nature of their othering. This emphasis on history and context is crucial in the exploration of gender equality, as it underscores the importance of challenging the structures that seek to define and constrain individuals' lives.

3.7 Symbolism and Imagery in the Pursuit of Gender Equality

In *Before She Sleeps*, symbolism and imagery play a crucial role in depicting the pursuit of gender equality. Panah, the sanctuary where women find refuge, symbolizes a space of empowerment and autonomy, representing the potential for gender equality in a restrictive society. Through vivid imagery, Shah illustrates Panah as a haven that contrasts sharply with the oppressive outside world, emphasizing the importance of safe spaces for self-expression. This symbolic representation aligns with Judith Butler's concept of gender performativity, showcasing how new identities can emerge in environments free from societal constraints. The novel also uses symbolism to critique the marginalization of women, portraying Panah as a site of resistance and solidarity against conventional gender roles.

3.7.1 Panah as a Symbol of Equality

In *Before She Sleeps*, Panah serves as a powerful symbol of gender equality and resistance. As a sanctuary for women escaping the oppressive norms of society, Panah represents a space where they can express their identities freely and pursue their right to self-determination. Shah describes Panah as "a place where women could breathe freely, away from the suffocating constraints of the outside world" (Shah 97). This depiction underscores the significance of Panah as a symbol of empowerment and autonomy.

Panah plays a variety of roles as a representation of gender equality. It symbolizes the potential for developing different settings where people can define themselves freely from the confines of social conventions. In addition to fostering a sense of support and unity, the Panah community emphasizes the significance of group action in the fight for equality. Panah shows the possibility of more equal gender relationships by challenging conventional gender

norms and expectations and creating a space where new gender performances might take place.

3.7.2 Butler's Performativity and Symbolism

The symbolism of Panah in *Before She Sleeps* can be further understood through the lens of Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity. Panah serves as a venue where innovative gender performances are possible, free from the constraints of societal norms. The women of Panah engage in actions and behaviors that challenge conventional gender norms, thereby demonstrating the fluidity and constructed nature of gender identity.

Butler's concept of performativity emphasizes the role of repetition in the formation of identity. Within Panah, the women engage in repeated acts that defy the societal expectations placed upon them, creating new performances that resist traditional gender roles. These behaviors highlight the capacity of individuals to forge new identities, rejecting the conventional roles that society has assigned them. Shah writes, "In Panah, they were not defined by what society dictated but by their own choices and actions" (Shah 104). This passage illustrates how the space of Panah allows for the emergence of identities that subvert traditional norms.

The process of redefinition and resistance that takes place in Panah is essential to the pursuit of gender equality. By offering a space where new performances can be enacted, Panah symbolizes the possibility of breaking free from the rigid structures that have historically defined gender. The symbolism of Panah thus aligns with Butler's theory, as it underscores the importance of agency and choice in the formation of identity. The women's ability to redefine themselves within this space becomes a powerful statement on the potential for transformative change in the quest for gender equality.

3.7.3 Reinterpreting Symbolism Through Gender Performance

Simone de Beauvoir's concept of "the other" provides a critical perspective on the symbolism of Panah in *Before She Sleeps*. In a society that seeks to marginalize and subordinate women, Panah represents a space where women can assert their subjectivity and challenge their othering. By coming together in a community of resistance, the women of Panah reject the roles imposed on them and assert their right to self-determination.

Panah's symbolism is deeply intertwined with the themes of resistance and solidarity. The women of Panah act as a network of support and encouragement for one another as they defy societal norms. Shah emphasizes this solidarity, stating, "Panah was not just a refuge; it was a sisterhood, a place where they could find strength in each other" (Shah 109). This sense of community is crucial in challenging the structures that seek to marginalize them, as it expands the importance of collective action in the fight for gender equality.

The symbolism of Panah is reinterpreted through the lens of gender performance, as the women actively participate in redefining their identities within this space. The communal resistance within Panah not only challenges the societal norms that have marginalized them but also redefines what it means to be a woman in their society. This redefinition is critical in the pursuit of gender equality, as it represents a rejection of the othering process and an assertion of self-determined identity.

Thus, Panah's role as a symbol of gender equality is multifaceted. It provides a space for individual expression, fosters a sense of community and shared purpose, and encourages the redefinition of identity through collective action. The imagery and symbolism associated with Panah reinforce the novel's thematic emphasis on the importance of creating spaces where marginalized voices can resist, redefine, and reclaim their identities.

Conclusion

Before She Sleeps by Bina Shah deftly explores gender identity, resistance, and equality via the growth of its characters, the structure of the story, and the use of symbols. The theoretical frameworks of Judith Butler and Simone de Beauvoir, which provide a thorough critique of gender stereotypes and societal oppression, greatly enhance the novel's examination of these subjects.

The idea of gender performativity as articulated by Judith Butler is embodied in Sabine's journey from compliance to resistance. Sabine's transition from being portrayed as cautious and obedient to being a leader of the rebellion highlights how gender roles are performative. She resists the rigid gender binary imposed by her culture by evolving from a passive participant to an active resistor, embodying Butler's theory that gender identity is a fluid construct that is constantly redefined via performances and acts. Simone de Beauvoir's concept of "the other" is essential to comprehending Sabine's metamorphosis at the same time. She begins as "the other" in a patriarchal society, but as she refuses to be subjugated and claims her agency, that role changes. Personal trauma causes this change, which results in her regaining her subjectivity and challenging the patriarchal structures that limit and define her.

Shah emphasizes the artificiality of gender standards by depicting enforced gender roles in the dystopian scenario. This portrays the state's control over women's bodies and lives as a means of upholding patriarchal beliefs, which is consistent with Butler's theory that gender roles are socially created as opposed to innate. Through acts of resistance, the women of Panah challenge the state's constrictive ideas of gender and autonomy, subverting traditional norms. The gender relations in the story are further complicated by the involvement of male allies. Certain male characters uphold patriarchal oppression, while

others lend assistance to women's resistance by providing an alternative masculinity that subverts conventional gender stereotypes. This sophisticated representation emphasizes that the fight for gender equality is a group endeavor that needs the cooperation of all members of society.

Panah symbolizes the possibility of a society with greater equality since it is a sign of resistance and unity. It provides a forum for women to rethink who they are and oppose the restrictive laws of the state. The ladies of Panah's collective struggle demonstrates the strength of solidarity in the face of structural injustice. Asserting gender equality is portrayed as contingent upon their solidarity, which is consistent with Butler's theory that social norms can be reshaped via group action. This investigation is made easier by the novel's non-linear narrative structure, which blends memories from the past with the present. Flashbacks shed light on the structural basis of oppression and the continuous fight for equality, supporting de Beauvoir's claim that comprehending the past is essential to resolving the inequality that exists now.

In conclusion, through its character development, symbolic themes, and narrative structure, *Before She Sleeps* delivers a powerful critique of gender conventions and societal injustice. Shah's book highlights the opportunities for questioning and redefining gender identities in the face of patriarchal domination by looking at the enforced gender roles, the subversion of conventional norms, and the importance of collective resistance. The synthesis of de Beauvoir's and Butler's ideas offers a sophisticated framework for comprehending these dynamics, emphasizing the continuous fight for gender parity and the possibility of revolutionary change. In the future, it will be important to investigate modern real-world analogies, broaden theoretical frameworks to incorporate intersectionality and promote collective resistance in the real world. The novel's influence and potential for societal change

can also be increased by advocating for gender equality in education, backing gender-inclusive policymaking, and fostering diverse representation in literature.

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